(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Excessive hair growth (hirsutism)

Hirsutism is where women have thick, dark hair on their face, neck, chest, tummy, lower back, buttocks or thighs. See a GP if it's a problem for you, particularly if you've noticed other symptoms such as irregular periods. This might be caused by a medical condition that can be treated.

Causes of hirsutism

Hirsutism is usually linked to changes in androgen levels ("male" hormones). It can happen if the level of these hormones increases or if your body becomes more sensitive to them.

The most common cause is polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/polyendocrine-metabolic-ovarian-syndrome-pmos/). This is a condition affecting the ovaries that can also cause symptoms such as acne and irregular periods.

Sometimes there's no obvious cause.

Rarely, hirsutism can be caused by:

- certain medicines such as some epilepsy medicines and steroids including anabolic steroids (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/anabolic-steroid-misuse/)
- other hormonal conditions like Cushing's syndrome (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/cushings-syndrome/) and acromegaly (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/acromegaly/)
- a tumour affecting your hormone levels

> If you have lighter, finer hair on your face or body, it's probably not hirsutism. Most women get more of this type of hair as they get older, particularly after the menopause (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause/).

See a GP if:

- you're a woman and you have thick, dark hair on your face, neck, chest, tummy, lower back, buttocks or thighs

The GP will check what's causing the hair growth.

You may have a blood test to measure your hormone levels. A change in your hormone levels is a common cause of hirsutism – and can also affect your periods.

Ask for an urgent GP appointment if:

You're a woman and:

- new thick, dark hair suddenly starts growing on your face and body
- your voice is getting lower
- your muscles are getting bigger

Treatments for hirsutism

If you have hirsutism, your GP may suggest:

- losing weight if you're overweight – this can help control hormone levels
- things you can do at home to remove or lighten the hair – such as shaving, waxing, plucking, hair removal creams or bleaching
- a prescription cream to slow hair growth on your face (eflornithine cream)
- taking a contraceptive pill if you've not been through the menopause yet – this can help control hormone levels

If these things do not help, or if your GP thinks you need further or more urgent tests and treatment, they may refer you to a specialist.

Longer-lasting hair removal

There are treatments that can get rid of unwanted hair for longer than the things you can do at home. But they're not usually permanent.

They're also not usually available on the NHS and can be expensive.

The 2 main treatments are:

- electrolysis – where an electric current is used to stop your hair growing
- laser hair removal

Make sure you research these treatments before trying them. They both have risks and the results are not the same for everyone.

Page last reviewed: 18 August 2025
Next review due: 18 August 2028